

Session 21: God's Response to Human Failure

Key Takeaways

- God's response to human failure is an invitation to come out of hiding and dialogue with him.
- The story of humanity's failure in the garden of Eden is less about a paradise that was lost and more about an opportunity for a paradise that was not achieved.

Reflection on Paradigm Ungained

"Wisdom is good, and we can safely assume that God did not intend to withhold it from humanity. But true wisdom must be acquired through a process, generally from instruction by those who are wise. The fall is defined by the fact that Adam and Eve acquired wisdom illegitimately (Gen. 3:22), thus trying to take God's role for themselves rather than eventually joining God in his role as they were taught wisdom and became the fully functional vice-regents of God involved in the process of bringing order. If humans are to work alongside of God in extending order ('subdue' and 'rule' [Gen. 1:28], they need to attain wisdom, but as endowment from God, not by seizing it for autonomous use. If ... from the start people were mortal, and pain and suffering were already a part of a not yet fully ordered cosmos, we cannot think of death and suffering as having been foisted on us by Adam and Eve's malfeasance ... Instead, we can have a much more charitable attitude toward Adam and Eve when we realize that it is not that they initiated a situation that was not already there; it is that they failed to achieve a solution ... that was in their reach. Their choices resulted in their failure to acquire relief on our behalf. Their failure meant that we are doomed to death and a disordered world full of sin. These are profoundly significant consequences for what was a serious offense. In contrast, Christ was able to achieve the desired result where Adam and Eve failed. We are all doomed to die because when they sinned we lost access to the tree of life. We are therefore subject to death because of sin. Christ succeeded and actually provided the remedy to sin and death. Some would follow this same line of reasoning to suggest that what we call original sin is the result of our ancestors 'pulling out of the program' prematurely. James Gaffney identifies these approaches as involving a view that our human condition is underdeveloped, failing to achieve the intended goal because we wanted to do it our way—not paradise lost, but, as it were, paradise ungained."

Walton, John (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic.

Trial in the Garden: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 3:8-13

⁸ and they **heard the sound** of **Yahweh God** walking **in the garden** in the wind of the day

Human Response

and **the human and his woman** **hid themselves**
from before the face of Yahweh God among the trees of the garden.

Yahweh's First Question

⁹ and **Yahweh God** called to the human, and said to him,
"Where are you?"

Human Response

¹⁰ and he **[the human]** said,
"I **heard the sound of you in the garden**,
and I was afraid because I was **naked (ערום)**
and **I hid myself**."

Yahweh's Second Question

¹¹ and he **[Yahweh God]** called to the human, and said to him,
"Who told you that you were naked (ערום)
Have **you eaten** from the tree of which I commanded you not **to eat**?"

Human Response

¹² and **the human** said,
"The woman whom you gave to be with me,
she gave me from the tree, and **I ate**."

Yahweh's Third Question

¹³ and **Yahweh God** said to the woman,
"What is this you have done?"

Human Response

and **the woman** said,
"The snake deceived me, and **I ate**."

Notice how the scene unfolds in an alternating fashion, juxtaposing Yahweh's actions with multiple evasive human responses.

Key Words in Genesis 3:8-13

The vocabulary of Genesis 3:8 was chosen in order to paint the portrait of Yahweh's first personal appearance, or theophany. Later theophany stories will draw upon and develop the imagery of this scene.

Word Study: The Sound/Voice of Yahweh — *Qol* (קול)

The phrase “the sound/voice of Yahweh” (Heb. *qol* / קול) refers to the sound of Yahweh's voice when he appears to address his people. It is usually loud, intimidating, and indistinguishable from thunder. The voice of Yahweh is sometimes depicted as a character in its own right.

Exodus 19:16-17 NASB*

¹⁶ So it came about on the third day, when it was morning, that there were **sounds** (קול) and lightning flashes and a thick cloud upon the mountain and a very loud trumpet sound, so that all the people who were in the camp trembled. ¹⁷ And Moses brought the people out of the camp to meet God, and they stood at the foot of the mountain.

*Kew Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 20:18-19 NASB*

¹⁸ All the people saw the ****sounds**** (קול) and the lightning flashes and the sound (קול) of the trumpet and the mountain smoking; and when the people saw it, they trembled and stood at a distance. ¹⁹ Then they said to Moses, “Speak to us yourself and we will listen; but let not God speak to us, or we will die.”

*Kew Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 7:89 NASB*

Now when Moses went into the tent of meeting to speak with him, he heard the **voice/sound** (קול) speaking to him from above the mercy seat that was on the ark of the testimony, from between the two cherubim; so he spoke to him.

*Kew Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 29:3-4 NASB

³ The voice of the LORD is upon the waters;
the God of glory thunders,
the LORD is over many waters.

⁴ The **voice** of the LORD is powerful,
the **voice** of the LORD is majestic.

Word Study: Walking — Hithalek (התהלך)

This picture of Yahweh walking about or strolling in the garden, waiting for the humans to join him, is a powerful image of divine and human intimacy idealized in the garden. The righteous of later generations who live outside of Eden are those who “walk/stroll with Yahweh,” that is, they relate to God in the Eden ideal.

Genesis 5:23-24 NASB

²³ So all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years. ²⁴ Enoch **walked with God**; and he was not, for God took him.

Genesis 6:8-9 NASB

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD. ⁹ These are the records of the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man, blameless in his time; Noah **walked with God**.

Genesis 17:1 NASB

Now when Abram was ninety-nine years old, the LORD appeared to Abram and said to him, “I am God Almighty; **walk before me and be blameless.**”

Leviticus 26:9-12 NASB

⁹ ... I will turn toward you and make you fruitful and multiply you, and I will confirm my covenant with you ...
¹¹ Moreover, I will make my dwelling among you, and my soul will not reject you. ¹² **I will walk among** you and be your God, and you shall be my people.

Word Study: The Wind of the Day — Ruakh Hayom (רוח היום)

Some interpreters take “the wind of the day” (Heb. *ruakh hayom* / רוח היום) to mean the breezy time of day, that is, in the morning or evening, in contrast to “the heat of the day” (see [Genesis 3:8](#)). Others take it to mean a storm because the words “wind” and “sound” are sometimes associated with thunderstorm theophanies ([Jer. 10:13](#); [Jer. 51:16](#)). The words “wind” and “day” are also associated with storms ([Isa. 27:8](#); [Zeph. 2:2](#)). Throughout Scripture, we see Yahweh’s personal appearances associated with storms and thunder, so the fact that the “sound” of Yahweh appears with wind is key to the storm imagery later in the Hebrew Bible.

“The time of the Lord’s visit is often translated as ‘the cool of the day’ or ‘the time of the evening,’ but the text reads only ‘at the wind of the day.’ Indeed, nothing in the context suggests that this refers to a time of day. In the light of the general context of the picture of God’s coming in judgment and power, the ‘wind’ which the author envisions is more likely intended to resemble that ‘great and powerful wind’ which blew on the ‘mountain of the LORD’ in 1 Kings 19:11. Thus the viewpoint of the narrative would be much the same as that in Job 38:1, where the Lord answered Job ‘from the whirlwind.’”

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-theological Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic.

Yahweh’s Seven Speeches and Many Questions

Just as God spoke 10 times over the course of seven days to establish the cosmic order as a sacred space, so here in Genesis 3, God speaks seven times to address the problem of disorder that has been introduced by the snake and the humans.

1. 3:9: And Yahweh Elohim called to the human and **he said** to him, “Where are you?”
2. 3:11: And **he said**, “Who told you that you are naked?”
3. 3:13: And **Yahweh Elohim said** to the woman, “What is this you have done?”
4. 3:14: And **Yahweh Elohim said** to the snake ...
5. 3:16: And to the woman, **he said** ...
6. 3:17: And to the man, **he said** ...
7. 3:22: And **Yahweh Elohim said**, “Look, the human has become like one of us ...”

Yahweh’s three questions display a patient desire that gives the humans an opportunity to own their failure: “Where?” “Who?” “What?” At each turn, Yahweh invites the humans to acknowledge their violation of the divine command, but the humans evade his questions every step of the way.

“[T]he question, ‘Where are you?’ is essentially rhetorical. “Where?” (אֵיךָ) is often used in this way in poetry (e.g., Isa. 33:18; 36:19; Ps. 42:3, 10), and a very close parallel is found in Genesis 4:9, where ‘Where is Abel your brother?’ is followed by ‘Listen, your brother’s blood is crying to me from the land,’ showing that God knows perfectly well what has happened to Abel. ... Just as a parent who sees where his children are hiding may shout out, ‘Where are you?’ in effect inciting them to come out, so does God. [W]e presume that this is what happened here: the couple emerge shamefaced from the trees. Their reply to God’s inquiry shows that they understood the question as an invitation to come out and explain their behavior.”

Wenham, Gordan J. (1987). [*Genesis 1-15*](#). Thomas Nelson Inc.

The humans blameshift at each step of the conversation: “the woman!” “the snake!” No one is able to take responsibility for their own choices. Notice how the man blames the one whom God provided as his ‘ezer, and the woman then blames the snake for her own misdirected desire.

Reflection Question

God responds to the first humans’ failure by seeking them out and pursuing relationship with them. What does this say about God’s character?